Wall. She writes in the following year, as she was drafting her stories, “I swing back and forth between too much awareness of certain insoluble problems (I mean on a larger scale—society, the world, Reagan, our new mood of meanness and suspicion in America) and what must be too little.”[25] In the first story, she personalizes “the danger of being an American in Europe” through a somber, defeated spin on a spy tale. The protagonist is the younger brother of a Fulbright scholar who claims the body of his sibling. The deceased brother’s obsession with the Berlin Wall led to his fatal shooting at the border. Though the younger brother claims to reject identification—“for the record, I am not a Berliner”—he returns to the city and is tempted to reenact his brother’s suicidal journey, to approach the border wall again from the West.[26] The result is a sense of doomed repeat by the Wall.

In the second story, “Our Wall,” Oates reimagines the 1962 murder of Peter Fechter by border guards as he tries to cross the border from the East. She writes again as an imagined younger brother and employs a grammatical sense of shared identification (“our”) with the Wall. The personal and political crises Oates writes about in her journal entries from Berlin are reflected in her own alternating close descriptions and dreamlike approaches to the Berlin Wall in the final pages of the work. She writes, as her protagonist approaches the forbidden, militarized border from its east side, “Someday it is whispered, we will overcome The Wall.” Within several lines she ends her story, however, and pursues a detached narrative point of view. Oates concludes with a declarative statement: “Come closer, have no fear, long before you were born The Wall was, and forever The Wall will endure.”[27]

Perhaps the most poignant rebuttal of the problem of American-German memory in the era of Cold War reacceleration can be found in Lorde’s poems from *Our Dead Behind Us*. Inspired in the year before Bitburg (1984) but revised and published the year following (1986), the book of poems tasks itself—and the genre of poetry—as an ambivalent yet critical form of historical reflection. While Oates’s short fiction is transfixed with the Berlin Wall, compelled by its totality and aura of alienation, Lorde purposes Cold War divides in Berlin and elsewhere to call for working with and across boundaries as a means to undermine them. As Sagri Dhairyam notes, *Our Dead Behind Us* “is a testament to ‘the burden of history,’ the overtly political freight that the poems carry. … The poems in [*Our Dead Behind*